



Busted

A newspaper front page goes up on the board with a claim that was once reported as true, and the form argues about whether they believe it. Then the evidence goes up, a graph or a document, and they work out what it shows before the verdict. Each day is four slides and about ten minutes, with nothing to print. Five stories for a week, from sugar to leaded petrol, and each one ends on the question that would have caught it.

Before you start. Tuesday's story is thalidomide and Wednesday's is smoking. A student may have a limb difference, or a parent who smokes, so keep both on the claims and the evidence and never ask about home. Friday's story is about how a food was sold, not about what anybody eats.

What you need

What	What it is
Slides	Nothing to print. Each story is four slides: the front page, the argument, the evidence and the verdict.
Page 2	The five stories in full, with what each graph shows and where it came from. For you, not for the board.

How it works

Step	What happens	Slides
1	Put up the front page and read the headline and the first lines aloud.	3, 7, 11, 15, 19
2	Read the claim. Hands up for agree and for disagree, then two or three say why.	4, 8, 12, 16, 20
3	Put up the evidence and ask what it shows before you say anything yourself.	5, 9, 13, 17, 21
4	Show the verdict and read out the question that would have caught it.	6, 10, 14, 18, 22

Worth knowing

- Each story takes about ten minutes. With only five minutes, show the front page and the evidence one morning and the verdict the next.
- The front pages are recreated for the lesson; the quotes on them and every number on a graph are real, and page 2 says where each one came from.
- Question the Headline, in Tutor Time, turns each of these stories into a full lesson with evidence cards.

Make sure you come back for Volume Two. Follow @thepastoralguide to hear when it lands.





The five stories, for you

What each claim was, what the evidence on the slides shows, and where it came from. Read the day's block before registration.

MONDAY • STORY 1

Caught by: Who paid for it?

Sugar is not a problem for your heart. Fat is.

The verdict is not that fat is harmless and sugar is the real villain. Current advice says to limit both. What was busted is the idea that the review was independent: the industry paid for it, saw it before publication and was pleased, and readers were never told.

Kearns C. E., Schmidt L. A. and Glantz S. A. (2016). Sugar industry and coronary heart disease research. *JAMA Internal Medicine*, 176(11), 1680–1685. • Bailey M. (2016). Sugar industry secretly paid for favorable Harvard research. *STAT News*, 12 September 2016.

TUESDAY • STORY 2

Caught by: Has it been tested, and by whom?

If a medicine is sold by a big company and prescribed by doctors, it must have been tested properly.

Some students may have a disability or a limb difference, or a family member who does. Keep the story on the company's claims and the evidence, and do not show photographs. The US bar is small because the drug was never approved there, not because Americans were luckier.

Wikipedia, Thalidomide and Thalidomide scandal, accessed September 2026. • Phillips S. (2020). How a courageous physician-scientist saved the U.S. from a birth-defects catastrophe. *UChicago Medicine*.

WEDNESDAY • STORY 3

Caught by: What is the evidence?

If doctors smoke them, cigarettes can't be that bad for you.

Some students will have parents or carers who smoke. The story is about how the adverts worked, not about the people who smoke, and nobody should be asked about home. The busted claim is that doctors smoking a brand made it safe; a survey with no method is not evidence.

Doll R. and Hill A. B. (1950). Smoking and carcinoma of the lung. *British Medical Journal*, 2(4682), 739–748. • Doll R. and Hill A. B. (1964). Mortality in relation to smoking: ten years' observations of British doctors. *British Medical Journal*, 1, 1399–1410. Rates as set out in the CDC's case study on this work.

THURSDAY • STORY 4

Caught by: Has it been tested, and by whom?

If nobody has proved something is harmful, it must be safe.

The graph shows lead in blood falling as lead came out of petrol, but lead paint and lead solder were banned in the same years, and a sharp class will say so. That is the right answer, not a problem: the US Environmental Protection Agency says the biggest fall followed the removal of lead from petrol.

Egan K. B. and others (2021). Blood lead levels in U.S. children ages 1–11 years, 1976–2016. *Environmental Health Perspectives*, 129(3). • US Environmental Protection Agency, Report on the Environment: Blood Lead (2023) and America's Children and the Environment: Lead (2026).

FRIDAY • STORY 5

Caught by: Who gains if I believe it?

A new food made in a factory by scientists is probably better for you than the old one.

This story is about how a product was sold and what the evidence later showed, not about what anybody eats. Keep it off good and bad foods and off anybody's lunch. The data does not make butter healthy: saturated fat raised the bad cholesterol slightly more than trans fat did. What was busted is that the factory fat was the healthier choice.

Mensink R. P. and Katan M. B. (1990). Effect of dietary trans fatty acids on high-density and low-density lipoprotein cholesterol levels in healthy subjects. *New England Journal of Medicine*, 323(7), 439–445. • World Health Organization (2024). Trans fat: fact sheet.

